

INFO6007

Project Management in IT

Week 09: Project Leadership, Governance and alignment

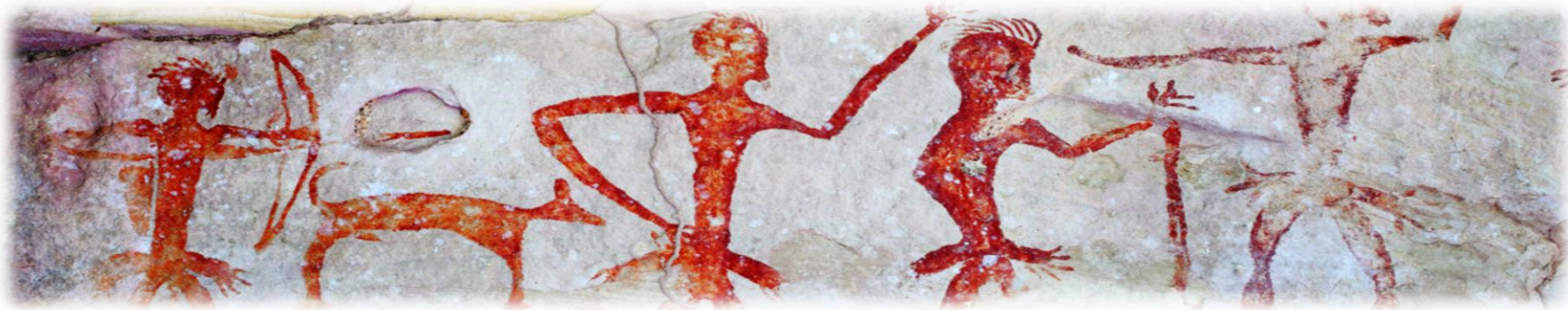
Semester 1, 2026



Acknowledgement of Country

I would like to acknowledge the Traditional Owners of Australia and recognise their continuing connection to land, water and culture. I am currently on the land of the Gadigal people of the Eora nation and pay my respects to their Elders, past, present and emerging.

I further acknowledge the Traditional Owners of the country on which you are on and pay respects to their Elders, past, present and future.



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Agenda

- Introduction
- Project Leadership
- Project Communication management
- IT Project Governance
- Alignment in IT Projects
- Integrating Leadership, Governance and Alignment

Introduction

Foundational concepts

- Leadership
 - Leadership is about **guiding and motivating the project team** to achieve objectives.
 - Leadership ensures the **people side** of IT projects works effectively.
- Governance
 - Governance provides the **formal structure of oversight and control** that keeps IT projects accountable.
 - Governance ensures IT projects are delivered **within scope, budget, and compliance boundaries**.
- Alignment
 - Alignment ensures the **project's goals match the organization's strategy** and business needs.
 - Alignment ensures IT projects **deliver not just technology, but business impact**.

Why leadership, governance and alignment are critical for projects?

- Leadership, governance, and alignment are **critical pillars** for IT project success because they directly influence decision-making, resource utilization, and the ability to deliver value that meets organizational goals.
- **Leadership** = The **captain of the ship**, motivating the crew and steering the direction.
- **Governance** = The **navigation system and rules**, ensuring the ship stays on course safely.
- **Alignment** = The **destination**, making sure the ship is headed where the organization actually wants to go.

Project Leadership

What is Project Leadership?

- Project leadership is the ability to **inspire, guide, and influence a project team and stakeholders** to achieve the project's objectives, going beyond just managing tasks and schedules.
- Key aspects of project leadership:
 - Vision and direction
 - Motivation and inspiration
 - Decision making under uncertainty
 - Change management
 - Stakeholder engagement

Project Leadership vs Project Management

Aspect	Project Management	Project Leadership
Definition	Project management is the application of knowledge, skills, tools, and techniques to plan, execute, and control projects so that they meet specific objectives within scope, time, cost, and quality constraints .	Project leadership is the ability to inspire, guide, and influence a project team and stakeholders to achieve the project's objectives, going beyond just managing tasks and schedules.
Characteristics	• Task-oriented and process-driven. • Ensures compliance with governance frameworks and standards. • Focuses on efficiency, resource allocation, and deliverables.	• People-oriented and vision-driven. • Builds team cohesion and trust while providing direction and motivation during uncertainty. • Focuses on long-term value, adoption, and transformation.
Focus	Tasks, processes, tools	People, vision, influence
Goal	Deliver on scope, time, cost, quality	Inspire, align, and drive adoption & value
Approach	Control, planning, monitoring	Motivation, guidance, adaptability
Orientation	Short-term efficiency	Long-term impact

Leader vs Manager

Aspect	Leader	Manager
Focus	People, vision, and inspiration.	Processes, tasks, and control.
Orientation	Future-oriented: asks <i>“Where are we going? Why does it matter?”</i>	Present-oriented: asks <i>“How do we get it done efficiently and correctly?”</i>
Approach	Motivates, influences, and empowers the team.	Plans, organizes, monitors, and controls work.
Style	Flexible, adaptive, and willing to take risks.	Structured, methodical, and risk-averse.
Outcome	Creates engagement, innovation, and long-term value.	Delivers outputs on time, within budget, and per scope.

Leadership Styles (ref Week 6)

- **Transformational:** Encourages innovation, embraces new technologies, and drives digital transformation.
 - **Strengths:** Builds high engagement and adaptability.
 - **Risk:** May overlook operational details.
- **Transactional:** Focuses on structure, rewards, and penalties.
 - **Strengths:** Clear accountability and discipline.
 - **Risk:** Can stifle creativity and initiative.
- **Autocratic:** Leader makes decisions unilaterally, with tight control.
 - **Strengths:** Fast decisions in emergencies.
 - **Risk:** Can cause low morale and lack of team input if used too often.
- **Laissez-Faire:** Hands-off style, giving freedom to highly skilled professionals.
 - **Strengths:** Encourages autonomy and innovation.
 - **Risk:** Can lead to confusion or lack of direction if the team is inexperienced.

Leadership Style – Adaptive/Agile

- One of the major leadership styles found in the industry today and rapidly gaining popularity.
- Agile or adaptive leadership is a **flexible, situational approach** that adjusts to changing project needs, team dynamics, and business priorities.
- Leaders focus on **empowering teams, enabling rapid adaptation, and fostering collaboration**, rather than relying solely on rigid hierarchies or strict processes.
- **Strengths:** Balances control and empowerment.
- **Risk:** Requires high awareness and skill to shift styles effectively.

Application of Project Leadership in IT Project contexts

- Agile Software Development
 - Leaders act as **servants and enablers** in Scrum or Kanban teams.
 - They remove blockers, facilitate communication, and help the team self-organize.
- Digital Transformation Projects
 - Leaders ensure the project aligns with **strategic objectives** like improved efficiency, automation, or customer experience.
 - They guide adoption across the organization and promote cultural change.
- Cloud or Infrastructure Projects
 - Leaders manage cross-functional teams (network, security, developers) and ensure smooth migration or deployment.
 - They handle risk, maintain communication with stakeholders, and adapt plans as technical challenges arise.

Why Project Leadership matter in IT?

- Navigating complexity and uncertainty
 - IT projects often deal with changing technologies, evolving requirements, and high uncertainty.
 - Strong leadership helps teams adapt quickly and make confident decisions under pressure.
- Driving team motivation and performance
 - Leaders inspire collaboration among diverse roles (developers, analysts, testers, business users).
 - They build morale, trust, and accountability; ensuring the team works as a unit, not just as individuals.
- Aligning with business strategy
 - Leaders bridge the gap between technical execution and business vision.
 - They make sure the project doesn't just “work” technically, but also delivers **real business value**.

Essential Skills for Project Leaders



Communication



Adaptability and Flexibility



Strategic Thinking and Vision



Risk management and Critical thinking



Decision making and Problem solving



Stakeholder management and Negotiation



Leadership and People management



Emotional Intelligence

Menti

- What is the most important leadership skill?
 - <https://www.menti.com/alnmn4v6b53t>



Project Communication management

Project Communications Management Overview

10.1 Plan Communications Management

- .1 Inputs
 - .1 Project charter
 - .2 Project management plan
 - .3 Project documents
 - .4 Enterprise environmental factors
 - .5 Organizational process assets
- .2 Tools & Techniques
 - .1 Expert judgment
 - .2 Communication requirements analysis
 - .3 Communication technology
 - .4 Communication models
 - .5 Communication methods
 - .6 Interpersonal and team skills
 - .7 Data representation
 - .8 Meetings
- .3 Outputs
 - .1 Communications management plan
 - .2 Project management plan updates
 - .3 Project documents update

10.2 Manage Communications

- .1 Inputs
 - .1 Project management plan
 - .2 Project documents
 - .3 Work performance reports
 - .4 Enterprise environmental factors
 - .5 Organizational process assets
- .2 Tools & Techniques
 - .1 Communication technology
 - .2 Communication methods
 - .3 Communication skills
 - .4 Project management Information system
 - .5 Project reporting
 - .6 Interpersonal and team skills
 - .7 Meetings
- .3 Outputs
 - .1 Project communications
 - .2 Project management plan updates
 - .3 Project documents updates
 - .4 Organizational process assets updates

10.3 Monitor Communications

- .1 Inputs
 - .1 Project management plan
 - .2 Project documents
 - .3 Work performance data
 - .4 Enterprise environmental factors
 - .5 Organizational process assets
- .2 Tools & Techniques
 - .1 Expert judgment
 - .2 Project management Information system
 - .3 Data representation
 - .4 Interpersonal and team skills
 - .5 Meetings
- .3 Outputs
 - .1 Work performance Information
 - .2 Change requests
 - .3 Project management plan updates
 - .4 Project documents updates

3 processes of Project Communication Management

1. Planning Communication Management

- Planning Communication Management is the process of **determining the project's communication needs and defining how information will be collected, distributed, stored, and managed.**
- It ensures that **all stakeholders receive the right information at the right time** in the right format.
- The main objectives of this step are:
 - Identify stakeholder's communications needs
 - Determine communication methods and channels
 - Define roles and responsibilities
 - Set communication frequency and timing
 - Document communication standards
 - Plan for feedback and 2-way communication

2. Managing Communications

- Managing Communications is the process of **collecting, creating, distributing, storing, and retrieving project information according to the communication management plan.**
- It ensures that the **right information reaches the right people at the right time.**
- The key objectives of this step are:
 - Implement Communication plan
 - Ensure accurate and timely information flow
 - Facilitate collaboration and feedback
 - Maintain stakeholder engagement
 - Handle information requests and issues

3. Monitoring Communications

- Controlling Communications is the process of **monitoring and measuring project communications to ensure they are effective, timely, accurate, and aligned with stakeholder needs**, and making adjustments as necessary.
- The main objectives of this step are:
 - Monitor communication effectiveness
 - Identify gaps and issues
 - Ensure compliance and standards
 - Implement corrective actions

IT Project Governance

Introduction

- IT Project Governance is the **framework of policies, roles, responsibilities, processes, and decision-making structures** that guide, monitor, and control IT projects.
- It ensures projects are **aligned with organizational objectives, comply with standards, manage risks, and deliver value.**
- The key components of IT Project Governance are:
 - Governance Structure
 - Processes and Policies
 - Roles and Responsibilities
 - Tools and Reporting

Governance Structure

- The governance structure is the **organizational framework of roles, responsibilities, committees, and decision-making authorities** that guides and oversees IT projects.
- It ensures **accountability, alignment with business objectives, and proper control of risks, resources, and outcomes.**
- There are 3 main roles:
 - Steering Committees
 - Project Management Offices
 - Project Sponsors

Steering Committee

- A **Steering Committee** (also called a Project Board in some frameworks) is a **group of senior stakeholders who provide strategic guidance, oversight, and decision-making authority** for a project.
- They ensure that the project **remains aligned with organizational goals, delivers value, and manages risks effectively.**
- This is typically composed of:
 - Project Sponsor
 - Senior Business Representatives
 - IT/Technical Leads
 - Finance/PMO Representatives
 - Other stakeholders

Steering Committee

- Importance of having a Steering Committee:
 - Provides **strategic alignment** and ensures IT projects deliver **real business value**.
 - Acts as a **decision-making body** for escalated issues.
 - Prevents projects from drifting into **scope creep or misalignment** with organizational goals.
- The main responsibilities of the Steering committee are:
 - Approve the Project Charter and Business Case
 - Set Strategic Objectives and Success Criteria
 - Approve Major Deliverables, Changes, and Scope Adjustments
 - Monitor Progress via Reports and Dashboards
 - Resolve Escalated Issues and Conflicts
 - Ensure Risk Management Plans are Adequate
 - Confirm Benefits Realization

Project Management Office (PMO)

- A **Project Management Office (PMO)** is a centralized **organizational unit or team that standardizes project management practices, provides governance support, and ensures projects align with business strategy.**
- It acts as a **bridge between project teams, leadership, and stakeholders**, enabling consistency, efficiency, and accountability.
- The main functions of a PMO in IT projects are:
 - Governance support
 - Performance monitoring
 - Training and Mentoring
 - Tools and Process Management
 - Risk and Issue Management

Project Management Office (PMO)

- Roles in a PMO:
 - PMO Director/Head
 - Project Controllers/Analysts
 - Project Support Officers
 - Methodology/Quality Experts
- Benefits of having a PMO:
 - **Consistency:** Standardized processes improve quality and predictability.
 - **Efficiency:** Optimized resource allocation and reduced duplication of effort.
 - **Transparency:** Clear reporting to stakeholders and executives.
 - **Alignment:** Projects stay aligned with strategic objectives.
 - **Continuous Improvement:** Lessons learned and best practices are captured for future projects.

Project Sponsors

- A **Project Sponsor** is a senior executive or stakeholder who champions the project, provides resources, and has ultimate accountability for the project's success.
- They act as the **link between the project team and the organization's strategic leadership**.
- Having a project sponsor is important in IT projects as:
 - **Provides Authority:** Grants the project manager the ability to execute plans and secure resources.
 - **Ensures Alignment:** Keeps the project tied to business strategy and objectives.
 - **Enables Risk Management:** Helps navigate organizational or strategic risks beyond the project manager's scope.

Governance Mechanisms

- Governance mechanisms are **structured methods and practices used to guide, monitor, and control IT projects.**
- They ensure that **projects are executed effectively, risks are managed, decisions are transparent, and outcomes align with organizational objectives.**
- Key objectives of the governance mechanisms are to:
 - Ensure decisions are made by the right people at the right level.
 - Define escalation paths for critical issues.
 - Clearly define roles, responsibilities, and authority.
 - Monitor risks, enforce policies, and ensure compliance with standards and regulations.

Common Governance Mechanisms

- Project Steering Committee
 - Provides strategic guidance, approves major changes, and monitors project performance.
- Project Management Office
 - Standardizes processes, monitors project KPIs, supports project managers, and ensures methodology compliance.
- Project Sponsor
 - Champions the project, approves budgets, resolves escalated issues, and ensures alignment with strategy.

Common Governance Mechanisms

- Stage-Gate / Phase-Gate reviews
 - Formal checkpoints at key project milestones to approve progress, deliverables, and resource allocation.
- Performance reporting and dashboards
 - Provides visibility into budget, schedule, scope, risks, and quality metrics.
- Risk and Issue escalation procedures
 - Defines how risks and issues are reported, evaluated, and resolved.
- Decision Making frameworks
 - Defines who can make which decisions and under what circumstances.
- Audits and reviews
 - Independent checks to ensure project compliance, quality, and alignment with governance standards.

Common Governance challenges

- Ambiguity in decision-making and accountability leads to confusion, delays, and finger-pointing. This could lead to critical decisions being delayed, and stakeholders not knowing whom to approach for approvals.
- Key stakeholders are not involved or informed sufficiently. This causes misalignment between project deliverables and business objectives; low adoption of IT systems.
- Project information is not timely, accurate, or clear. This leads to teams misunderstanding requirements; stakeholders being unaware of risks or progress.

Common Governance challenges

- Projects are executed without clear alignment to organizational goals. This leads to IT investments failing to deliver expected business value.
- Governance processes do not actively monitor or escalate risks and issues. This might lead to problems escalating unnoticed, leading to delays or project failure.
- Teams or stakeholders resist governance processes or project decisions causing delays, reduced compliance, and low adoption of project outcomes.

Best practices

- **Clearly define mechanisms at the start** of the project.
- **Integrate governance into daily operations** rather than treating it as a separate activity.
- **Ensure transparency and documentation** for all decisions and approvals.
- **Use tools and dashboards** to automate tracking and reporting.
- **Adapt mechanisms to project scale and complexity** – smaller projects need lighter governance.

Alignment in IT Projects

What is Alignment?

- In project management, **Alignment** means ensuring that the **goals, activities, and outcomes of an IT project are in harmony with the broader business strategy, stakeholder expectations, and organizational priorities.**
- Dimensions of Alignment:
 - Strategic Alignment
 - Ensuring the project supports the organization's long-term goals, mission, and vision.
 - Business-IT Alignment
 - Ensuring IT solutions deliver **real business value** and not just technical outputs.
 - Stakeholder Alignment
 - Ensuring that the expectations of executives, end-users, customers, and regulators are properly managed and satisfied.
 - Team Alignment
 - Ensuring project teams share a **common understanding of objectives, roles, and priorities.**

Why alignment matters in IT Projects?

- **Maximizes Business Value:** Projects that are aligned deliver outcomes that directly support organizational objectives.
- **Reduces Wasted Effort:** Prevents teams from building features or systems that aren't useful to the business.
- **Improves Stakeholder Satisfaction:** Ensures expectations are managed and met.
- **Enhances Decision-Making:** Helps prioritize projects and resources based on strategic fit.
- **Boosts Adoption:** Users are more likely to embrace IT systems that align with their needs and workflows.

Frameworks for Alignment

- Strategic Alignment Model (SAM) - Henderson & Venkatraman
 - One of the most cited frameworks for aligning **business strategy** with **IT strategy**.
- Balanced Scorecard (BSC) - Kaplan & Norton
 - A performance measurement framework that links projects and activities to strategic objectives.
- COBIT (Control Objectives for Information and Related Technology)
 - An IT governance and management framework by ISACA.
- ITIL (Information Technology Infrastructure Library)
 - A best practice framework for IT service management.
- TOGAF (The Open Group Architecture Framework)
 - An enterprise architecture framework that aligns IT architecture with business strategy.

Strategic Alignment Framework

- The model suggests that successful organizations **align business strategy and IT strategy** across two main dimensions:
 - Strategic Fit
 - External: Business environment & IT environment.
 - Internal: Organizational structure & IT infrastructure.
 - Functional Integration
 - Business strategy ↔ IT strategy.
 - Business infrastructure ↔ IT infrastructure.
- Why SAM matters in IT Projects?
 - Ensures IT projects are **not just technical exercises** but directly linked to business value.
 - Helps avoid **misalignment issues**.
 - Provides a **framework for communication** between IT and business executives.

Strategic Alignment Framework

- There are 4 domains of SAM:
 - **Business strategy:**
 - Defines the company's vision, goals, competitive positioning, and market approach.
 - **IT strategy:**
 - How IT will support or enable the business strategy. Cover technology scope, IT governance, and competencies.
 - **Organisational infrastructure and processes:**
 - Structure, roles, decision-making processes, and capabilities of the business.
 - **IT infrastructure and processes:**
 - Hardware, software, networks, applications, and IT capabilities.

Balanced Scorecard

- Traditional metrics (like profit, ROI) only measure the past.
- The Balanced Scorecard integrates **financial + non-financial measures** to track whether strategies are actually being executed.
- It answers 4 key questions:
 - **Financial Perspective** → “How do we look to shareholders?”
 - **Customer Perspective** → “How do customers see us?”
 - **Internal Business Process Perspective** → “What must we excel at?”
 - **Learning and Growth Perspective** → “Can we continue to improve and create value?”

Balance Scorecard – The 4 perspectives

- Financial perspective
 - Measures: Revenue growth, ROI, cost savings, profitability.
 - Example: Did the ERP system reduce operational costs?
- Customer perspective
 - Measures: Customer satisfaction, retention, acquisition, service quality.
 - Example: Did the new mobile app improve customer experience ratings?
- Internal process perspective
 - Measures: Efficiency, quality, innovation, delivery times.
 - Example: Did DevOps pipelines reduce release cycle time?
- Learning and growth perspective
 - Measures: Employee skills, knowledge management, IT capability, culture.
 - Example: Did staff training on cloud tools improve productivity?

Agile Alignment to Value streams

- A **value stream** is the sequence of activities that an organization undertakes to deliver value (a product or service) to a customer.
- Focuses on **end-to-end value delivery**, rather than siloed departmental outputs.
- Types:
 - **Operational Value Streams** → How the business delivers value to end customers (e.g., customer support, product delivery).
 - **Development Value Streams** → How the organization develops the systems and software that enable operational value streams.

Integrating Leadership, Governance, and Alignment

- Leadership – People & Direction
 - Leaders **set the vision, motivate teams, and manage change.**
 - Without leadership, IT projects risk **low morale, poor communication, and mismanaged expectations.**
- Governance – Oversight & Accountability
 - Governance defines **roles, responsibilities, structures, and decision-making mechanisms.**
 - Without governance, projects face **scope creep, poor accountability, and unmanaged risks.**
- Alignment – Strategic Fit & Value Delivery
 - Alignment ensures IT projects are connected to **business strategy and outcomes.**
 - Without alignment, IT projects risk **delivering tech that doesn't solve business problems.**

The triad of success

- Leaders provide vision and influence, while governance ensures checks and balances.
- Leaders communicate the business vision and align the team's daily work with it.
- Governance frameworks ensure project portfolios map to strategic goals.
- Leadership + Governance + Alignment Together
 - **Leadership** drives the people.
 - **Governance** provides the rules of the game.
 - **Alignment** ensures everyone plays the right game.

References

- Schwalbe, K., 2018. Project Communication Management. In: *Information Technology Project Management*. Boston: Cengage, pp. 425-462.

For You!

End of Lecture Questions

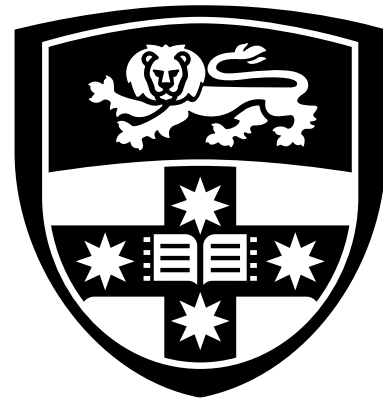
- Define **project leadership** in the context of IT and explain how it differs from **project management**.
- What is the difference between a **leader** and a **manager** in IT project contexts?
- What is **IT project governance** and why is it critical for project success?
- Who are **project sponsors**, and what is their responsibility within project governance?
- Briefly explain the **Strategic Alignment Model (SAM)** and its four domains.
- How does the **Balanced Scorecard** help in measuring IT project success?
- How do **leadership, governance, and alignment** complement one another in achieving IT project success?

Case Study

- **Background:** A university launches the SmartCampus Project to transform student services with:
 - A new portal for enrollment, payments, and course registration.
 - A mobile app for timetables and notifications.
 - Data analytics to improve student retention.
- **Challenges**
 - **Leadership:** The project manager is technically skilled but poor at motivating the team or engaging academic staff. Communication breaks down.
 - **Governance:** No clear steering committee or decision-making structure. Privacy compliance is considered too late.
 - **Alignment:** IT focuses on “cool features” (like gamification) that don’t support the university’s strategy of improving student retention.
- **Outcome:** After 18 months, the project is **over budget, behind schedule**, and students find the portal confusing. Leaders question whether it delivers any real value.

Case-study based questions

- What leadership style would have been more effective here?
- What governance structures should have been in place?
- How was the project misaligned with the university's strategy?
- How do failures in leadership, governance, and alignment reinforce each other?
- Which factor (leadership, governance, or alignment) most contributed to the project's struggles?



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